

01 / The Friction Map

The Friction Map

Where does the work get stuck, and who feels it?

Choose one process and walk through it with leaders and the people doing the work. Record what actually happens, separate evidence from assumptions, and agree on where to begin.

Questions to work through

1. What should this process make possible, and what matters to the people doing it?
2. Where do people wait, enter information twice or send work back for corrections?
3. How often does it happen, and who gets held up?
4. What have we observed or measured, and what is still an assumption?
5. Where should we start, considering impact, effort and the team's readiness?

Illustrative example, not a client case

For a program registration, staff copy the same details from a form to a spreadsheet and then to the CRM. Before building an integration, follow a few registrations and ask why the copying happens. The spreadsheet may no longer serve a purpose.

Fill in together

Organization / team

Internal lead

Date / version

The process and the people

Start and finish, steps, people and systems

Friction and evidence

Where work gets stuck; frequency, time, errors; sources and missing data

What is behind it?

Verified causes, assumptions, concerns and what to preserve

Where do we start together?

First improvement, why it matters, owner and review date

Leave with a mapped process, evidence and a shared decision on where to start.

02 / Before the Bot

Before the Bot

Do we need this task at all?

Start with the outcome and consider the options: remove, simplify, use an existing solution, automate or build. Choose based on the need and the ongoing cost. AI is an option, not the starting point.

Questions to work through

1. Who uses the result, and what would happen if we stopped doing this task?
2. Which steps could we remove or simplify without losing what matters?
3. Could a tool or capability we already have be enough?
4. What needs human judgment, and where could clear rules or AI help?
5. What will it take to run and maintain, and what small test would help us choose?

Illustrative example, not a client case

A team prepares a weekly report from three files. Before building an agent to produce it, ask who reads it and what they need. A saved view in the existing system might answer the question without another report.

Fill in together

Organization / team

Internal lead

Date / version

The need behind the task

Who benefits; the outcome and what must stay

Options considered

Remove, simplify, use what exists, automate or build; benefits and limits

Our choice and why

Benefit, total cost, privacy, risk, maintenance and owner

The first test

What to try, who will check, when, and what would change our decision

Leave with a reasoned choice and a small test before committing to a build.

03 / The Human Line

The Human Line

Where does a person need to stay involved?

Work through each action. Decide what can run automatically, where the system assists and a person checks and decides, and what stays entirely human. Set the boundary around the cost of error, context and relationships worth protecting.

Questions to work through

1. What harm could an error cause, and how can someone correct or challenge it?
2. Where do empathy, context or human judgment matter?
3. What may the system do, and what needs review and approval before action?
4. When must it stop and hand over, and to whom?
5. What information and training does the reviewer need, and how will we check that review actually happens?

Illustrative example, not a client case

For a scholarship application, the system can check for missing documents and draft a summary with sources. A person checks the summary and decides eligibility. A sensitive case gets a personal conversation; missing information pauses the decision.

Fill in together

Organization / team

Internal lead

Date / version

The action and its risks

Who is affected, cost of error, sensitive information and human contact

The boundary we chose

Automatic / assistance with human approval / human-only; allowed and prohibited actions

Stop and hand over

Clear triggers, named owner and backup, and a manual fallback

How will we test the boundary?

Review evidence, decision records, an exception scenario and a review date

Leave with decision boundaries, a named owner and a clear path for exceptions.

04 / Time for What?

Time for What?

What will the time we free up make possible?

Before making a change, agree on what the recovered time should make possible. Afterward, check the actual saving, including review and maintenance, and what changed for people. A lighter workload is a worthwhile outcome too.

Questions to work through

1. How much time and effort does this task take today, and how do we know?
2. What would the team like to do with the time recovered?
3. How much time will review, corrections and maintenance still take?
4. Was time actually freed up, or did the work move to someone else?
5. What improved in service or workload, and what do the people affected say?

Illustrative example, not a client case

For illustration: a weekly report that took 3 hours now takes 1, including review. The team plans to use the 2 hours for calls with families. A month later, check whether the calls happened and helped, rather than stopping at the hours saved.

Fill in together

Organization / team

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Before and after

Hours per period at comparable workload; data source; review, corrections and maintenance

What is the time for?

The team's chosen purpose, owner and how time will actually be allocated

What actually changed?

Net time, service quality, workload, usage and feedback

Review and next decision

Date, participants, evidence and what to change if the benefit did not materialize

Leave with a purpose for recovered time and a way to check the real benefit.